

Common yellowthroat

Geothlypis trichas

- ↔ 4in (10cm)
- 📍 N. and C. America
- ⊗ Common

This New World warbler is common among damp thickets and reedbeds across most of North America. Mainly greenish brown, the common yellowthroat has a bright yellow chin, throat, and breast which, in the male, are set off by a striking black face mask, edged with white. It feeds close to the ground on small insects, usually in dense cover, but is often betrayed by its “wichity-wichity-wichity” song.

Crested oropendola

Psarocolius decumanus

- ↔ 14–20in (36–51cm)
- 📍 N. and E. South America
- ⊗ Common

Looking mainly black from a distance, but with a striking yellow tail and a long, heavy white bill, this Amazonian bird’s breeding colonies consist of up to 100 intricately woven hanging nests suspended from a tree. The tree is usually isolated from the forest edge to deter arboreal predators such as snakes; it may also be chosen because it contains the extra defense measure of a nest of hornets.

Yellowhammer

Emberiza citrinella

- ↔ 7in (18cm)
- 📍 Europe and Central Asia
- ⊗ Common

The yellowhammer can be a conspicuous feature of farmland and bushy heaths—especially the bright yellow male singing with a rapid, repeated “tzi-tzi-tzi-tzi-tzi-tzeeee.” On sunny summer days, it may sing nonstop for hours. Yellowhammers join other buntings and finches in flocks that forage on the ground for seeds, especially in arable fields with plenty of weeds and spilled grain.



Spotted towhee

Pipilo maculatus

- ↔ 9in (23cm)
- 📍 W. US, SW. Canada, Mexico, Guatemala
- ⊗ Common

The spotted towhee was considered to be the same species as the Eastern towhee, but differences in their voice and plumage resulted in their separation into distinct species. However, the two species hybridize where their range overlaps. Spotted towhees forage on the ground to feed on insects, caterpillars, and seeds. They move in pairs or alone, but small family groups stay together after the nesting season.

Painted bunting

Passerina ciris

- ↔ 5in (13cm)
- 📍 S. North America and Mexico
- ⊗ Near threatened

Aptly named, the male painted bunting is the most colorful North American bird, with a vivid blue head, bright green mantle, and scarlet rump and underparts. Yet, despite its striking appearance, it can be difficult to see among the dense foliage that it favors; the confusion of colors helps to disguise its outline. The female is even less visible, being green overall. It feeds mainly on seeds, supplemented by small animals, but nurtures its young exclusively on insects.



Scarlet tanager

Piranga olivacea

- ↔ 7in (18cm)
- 📍 North and South America
- ⊗ Common

A male scarlet tanager in breeding plumage is a striking sight, with a bright crimson head and body, and contrasting black wings and tail. Outside the breeding season, it exchanges the red for green, to resemble the far less flamboyant female. These birds feed on insects, which they find in treetops, along with some fruits. After breeding in the deciduous woodlands of eastern North America, they migrate south to winter in the tropical forests of western Amazonia.

pointed red
crest in male



Northern cardinal

Cardinalis cardinalis

- ↔ 9in (23cm)
- 📍 North America
- ⊗ Common

One of North America’s most eye-catching birds, the northern cardinal is instantly recognizable by its crest and crimson color. Its exotic appearance makes it look like a summer migrant, but it is actually a year-round resident throughout most of its range. Females are olive-brown with darker wings and tails. Like males, they have conspicuous, pointed crests.

Other species

- Andean cock-of-the-rock
Rupicola peruvianus » p89
- Black-and-red broadbill
Cymbirhynchus macrorhynchos » p299
- Black-capped social weaver
Pseudonigrita cabanisi » pp204–05
- Collared sunbird
Anthreptes collaris » p216
- Greater bird-of-paradise
Paradisaea apoda » pp318–19
- Mountain chickadee
Poecile gambeli » p56
- Red-billed quelea
Quelea quelea » p225
- Scottish crossbill
Loxia scotica » p143

- Welcome swallow
Hirundo neoxena » p355
- Woodpecker finch
Camarhynchus pallidus » p125
- Yellow-billed cough
Pyrrhocorax graculus » p161